aircraft on the tarmac, came up to me and wanted directions to the duty-free shop. I was absolutely flabbergasted. Hadn't they seen from the air how devastated the countryside was? The buzz on the airfield of dozens of aircraft from different countries offloading their humanitarian cargo? Was this some jaunt to do some shopping and carry back duty-free liquor? I left them to their own devices.

During the time I was in Myanmar, discussions on the Kaladan Multi-Modal Transport Project (KMMTP) were ongoing. Initially, India had tried to persuade Bangladesh to offer transport and transit rights through the Chittagong port, which is less than 200 km away from Agartala, the capital of Tripura. However, the then dispensation in Bangladesh was not favourably inclined towards India and steadfastly refused to even consider the proposal, which would have been beneficial to both countries. The Kaladan project envisaged connecting Kolkata port with Myanmar's Sittwe Port by sea, then from Sittwe to Paletwa via the Kaladan River through barges, and lastly from Paletwa to Lawngtlai, Mizoram by road. Compared to the 1880 km-long route through the congested and vulnerable Siliguri Corridor, the Kaladan project would halve the distance to a mere 950 km. The Indian and Myanmar governments signed the Kaladan multimodal project agreement in 2008, and work on the project commenced in 2010, with a deadline of 2014. However, the project has been plagued by setbacks on account of faulty planning and coordination issues. The project budget was proposed to be Rs 536 crore in 2008 but is now estimated to be more than Rs 3200 crore, owing to the delays and inclusion of additional works overlooked earlier. The work also suffered due to the intimidation and attacks on the project by active Myanmar insurgent groups, the Arakan Army (AA) and the Arakan Rohingya Salvation Army, variously funded

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